A Successful Life of Service

The word received as the word of God, suffering imitated well, and a hope that Paul calls his crown — what is your glory and joy?

Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5
An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

02 1:6–10
The Many Faces of the Gospel

03 2:1–12
Delivering the Gospel

04 2:13–20
A Successful Life of Service

05 3:1–13
Facing Tribulation

06 4:1–12
A Life That Pleases God

07 4:13–18
The Rapture of the Church

08 5:1–11
The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

09 5:12–22
The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

10 5:23–28
'Til We Meet Again

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

Converts, countrymen, crown

1 Thessalonians 2:13–20 · Outline I–III

I · The converts

2:13–14 · Their success

- Welcomed the word as the Word of God
- It keeps working in those who believe
- Followed the Judean churches — in suffering

II · The countrymen

2:15–16 · Their sin

- Killed the Lord and the prophets
- Persecuted Paul; forbade preaching to Gentiles
- Wrath has come upon them

III · The crown

2:17–20 · Its sureness

- Torn away in presence, not in heart
- Hindered by Satan
- “You are our glory and joy”

The success of these converts is not measured in comfort or ease. It is measured in faithfulness under fire.

How they received the Word

1 Thessalonians 2:13 · I.A — Divine authenticity and divine achievement

Divine authenticity · 13a
δέχομαι welcomed · G1209

- Not the word of men — the Word of God
- An active, intentional welcome
- Verbal, plenary inspiration: every word, every part

vs

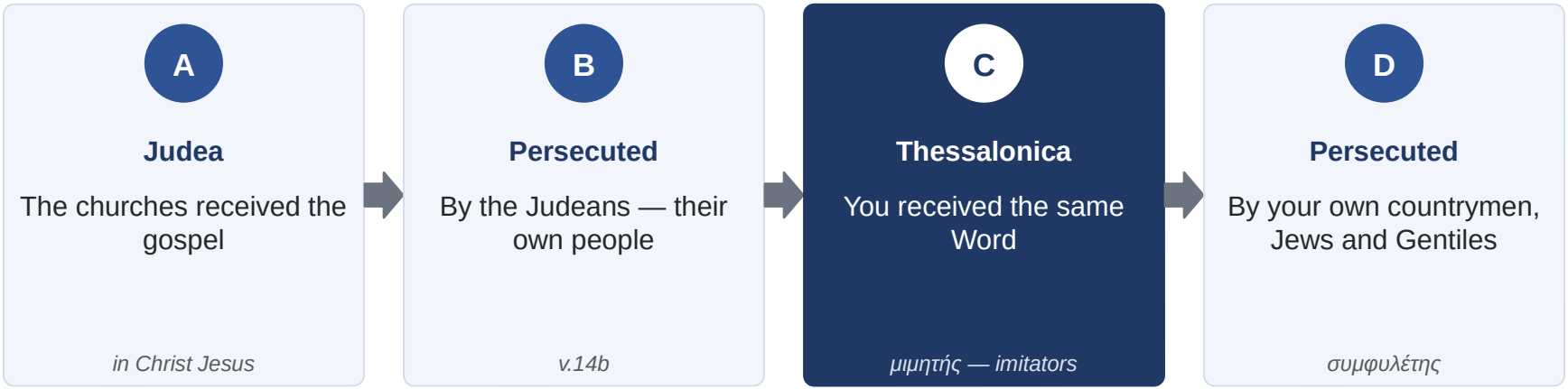
Divine achievement · 13b
ἐνεργέω effectively works · G1754

- Works — present tense, not “worked”
- Ongoing operation in believers
- Discipleship for a lifetime, not only salvation

A word from men can be debated, modified, or ignored. The Word of God demands a response. It carries authority.

Imitators — in consequence

1 Thessalonians 2:14 · I.B — How they acted on the Word



They heard the Word, believed the Word, acted on the Word — and paid for it with suffering. That is the mark of genuine reception: faithful reception produces a predictable result — not comfort, but conflict.

The sin of Paul’s countrymen

1 Thessalonians 2:15–16 · II.A–E — Five expressions

A **Provocation · 15a**

Killed the Lord Jesus and their own prophets, and persecuted Paul

B **Presumption · 15b**

“They do not please God” — they pleased themselves

C **Perversity · 15c**

“Contrary to all men” — the gift used as a wall, not a door

D **Prejudice · 16a**

Forbidding the gospel to the Gentiles “that they may be saved”

E **Punishment · 16b**

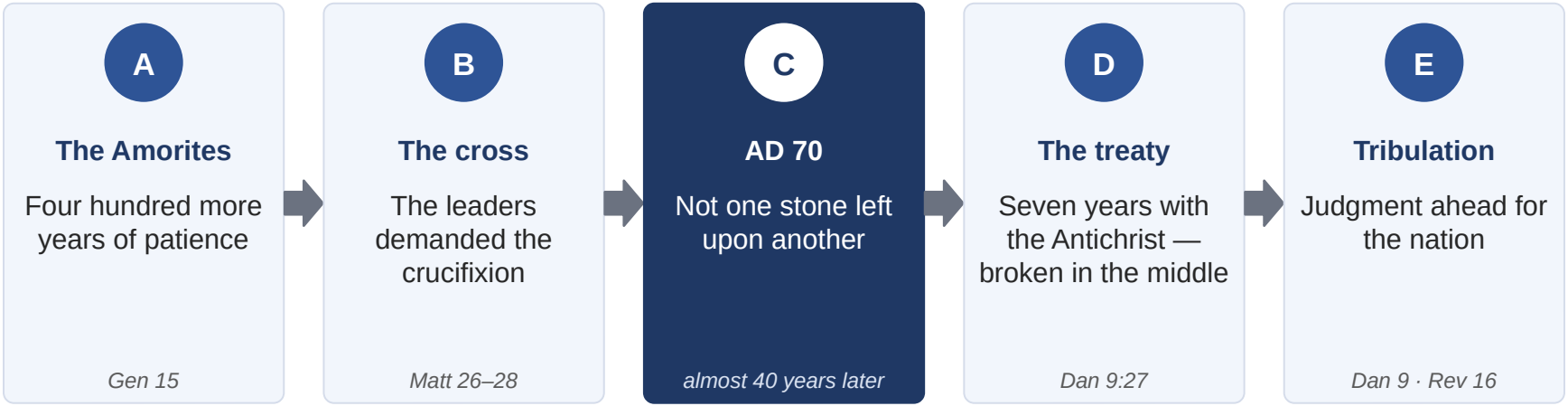
“To fill up the measure” — wrath has come upon them

Gk **ἀναπληρόω · G378**

God’s patience is real, but it has a limit — His justice is as certain as His grace

“Wrath has come” — as certain as if done

1 Thessalonians 2:16b · II.E — Their punishment



Romans 8:30 logic: “whom He justified, these He also glorified.” Are you glorified yet? No — but it is as certain as if it had already happened. So is this wrath.

Torn away, hindered, rewarded

1 Thessalonians 2:17–20 · III.A–B — Paul's desire and delight

v.17	Taken away in presence, not in heart	**ἀπορφανίζω** orphaned — torn from his children
v.18	Satan hindered us — though not everything is Satan's fault (James 1)	**ἐγκόπτω** cut the path — strategic opposition
v.19a	Our hope, joy, crown — at the judgment seat of Christ	**στέφανος** the victor's wreath — people won
v.19b	"In the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at His coming"	**παρουσία** here, the Rapture
v.20	"For you are our glory and joy"	**δόξα** they reflect what God did

Use things and love people

1 Thessalonians 2:19–20 · Conclusion — John Phillips

Solomon		David — and Paul
• A good start • Rejoiced in women, power and riches • Loved things and used people • A colossal failure in God’s eyes	vs	• A mid-life failure — and repentance (Ps 51) • Served God faithfully • Used things and loved people • Paul: people as crowns laid at Jesus’ feet

“Only one life will soon be past; only what’s done for Christ will last.” What is your glory and joy?

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 2:13–20 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. The Word “effectively works” (energeō) in believers — present tense, ongoing. What does this say about the role of Scripture beyond the moment of salvation?

2. The sermon contrasts Solomon and David. What does Paul’s crown (stephanos) reveal about what he truly valued?

Apply

Receive the Word as the Word of God

Before your next time in the Word, pray: “Lord, I receive this as Your Word, not a man’s word. Let it work in me.”

Use Things and Love People

Name one person whose growth in Christ you are investing in — or ask God this week to show you who it should be.

In one line: The Word received as God’s Word keeps working, will cost something — and the people we serve become our crown.